MY PHILOSOPHY OF TEACHING & LEARNING

Teaching and learning is

A Kaleidoscope of Possibilities

Keerthika Mohanmoorthy · ECE 245 · Curriculum model: Reggio Emilia



I believe learning is **never made from one piece alone**. When children, families, educators, community and environment come together through relationships, reflection and inquiry, **new patterns of possibility emerge**, and no two patterns are ever the same.

MY COMMITMENT

I will not teach children to fit a fixed pattern. I will listen, observe, reflect and turn the kaleidoscope with them, so new possibilities can emerge.

Bold colour = link to theory Highlighted = my practice



FACET 1 THE CHILD · COLOURED PIECES

I believe children are like the coloured pieces of a kaleidoscope: each one brings a colour, shape and story no other piece can.

Every child arrives with their own identity, language, culture and theories about the world. **Malaguzzi (1994)** reminds educators that the image we hold of the child is where teaching begins, and he describes children as rich in potential, competent and connected to others. Seeing children this way means I listen more and direct less. **If children became curious about shadows, I would offer flashlights, coloured acetate and translucent loose parts, write down their theories in their own words, and invite them to test and revise those ideas over several days.** This is the Reggio Emilia image of the child in action.



FACET 2 THE FAMILY · MIRRORS

I believe families are the mirrors: they reflect each child's identity back into learning and multiply what I can see.

Without mirrors, a kaleidoscope shows only scattered pieces; without families, I would see only part of the child. ***How Does Learning Happen?*** states plainly that *"families are experts on their children"* **(Ontario Ministry of Education, 2014, p. 7)** and calls for reciprocal relationships. To me, families are not an audience for the curriculum; they are contributors to it. **I would ask families about routines, home languages and celebrations, then bring that knowledge into provocations such as family recipes, songs or labels in home languages. I would also invite families to add their own interpretations to documentation panels**, as Reggio Emilia treats families as true partners.



FACET 3 THE EDUCATOR · THE LENS

I believe the educator is the lens: I do not choose the pattern, I help bring it into focus.

The **College of Early Childhood Educators (2020)** describes critical reflection as *"the active process of engaging with difficult concepts, tensions and uncertainties"* **(p. 12)** and positions educators as co-learners who make learning visible through documentation. A lens that is never cleaned distorts the view, so I keep questioning my own assumptions. **When a planned experience does not engage children, I would not call it a failure. I would revisit my notes and photos with colleagues, ask what children were communicating and what I overlooked, then change the materials, space or timing and try again.** This is how Reggio educators work as researchers alongside children.



FACET 4 THE COMMUNITY · THE PATTERN

I believe community is the larger pattern: it connects each piece to people, places and knowledge beyond the classroom.

Toulouse (2018) describes a holistic circle of learning with the child at the centre, surrounded by family, community, educators and Mother Earth, guided by the teaching that no child is left out. Community holds knowledge (Elders, knowledge keepers, local stories and places) that may not be represented within a single dominant curriculum perspective. Honouring Indigenous ways of knowing alongside other perspectives widens the pattern for every child. **If children showed interest in their neighbourhood, I would extend the inquiry through community walks and library or garden visits and, following proper protocol, invite an Elder to share stories. I would also ask whose voices are missing from our books and materials.** In Reggio Emilia, the community is a partner in learning, not a backdrop.



FACET 5 THE ENVIRONMENT · THE LIGHT

I believe the environment is the light: without it the pieces stay hidden; with it, endless patterns appear.

A kaleidoscope reveals nothing in the dark. **Wien (2018)** explains that engagement and expression grow when children have calm, uncluttered space, materials in view, unhurried time, and an adult documenting meaningful moments. This connects with the Reggio Emilia view of the environment as an active participant in learning: it shapes what children notice, try and communicate. **I would design flexible spaces with natural materials, loose parts, mirrors and a light table at children's height, protect long blocks of uninterrupted play, and display children's documentation at their eye level.** Before setting up, I would ask: What does this space invite, and who can access it?



MODEL REGGIO EMILIA · THE TURN

Reggio Emilia is the turn of the kaleidoscope: every shared turn by children and adults creates a new pattern.

Edwards et al. (2012) describe Reggio Emilia as a relationship-based approach in which children express their thinking through the hundred languages (drawing, building, clay, movement, light and words) and in which documentation and revisiting ideas drive long-term projects. Curriculum is not a fixed plan; it is co-constructed with children, one turn at a time, so the pattern belongs to everyone who turns it. **Across every facet, I commit to observing before planning, offering many languages for expression, documenting and revisiting children's ideas, and planning projects with children, families and community.**

References

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